



# MyGurukul

SACRED WISDOM — SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2026



## SACRED TEXT

*prāṇātyaye tathā jñānādācāranmadirāmapī d  
ādeśīto dharmaparaiḥ punaḥ saṁskāramarhati e  
etatte sarvamākhyātāṁ kaunteyābhakṣyabhakṣaṇam d  
prāyaścittavidhānena sarvametena śuddhyati e  
gurutalpaṁ hi gurvarthaṁ na dūṣayati mānavam d  
uddālakaḥ śvetaketuṁ janayāmāsa śiṣyataḥ e*

— 600301 (Chapter 12), Verses 22-24

## GURU'S INTERPRETATION

These verses from the Mahabharata offer nuanced perspectives on dharma and transgression, urging us to look beyond rigid rules and understand the underlying intent. The first verse speaks of dire circumstances where even consuming intoxicants (madirāmapī) is permissible, particularly if it aids in preserving life (prāṇātyaye) or attaining knowledge (jñānādācāran). However, the verse emphasizes that such an act, deemed against dharma by some, necessitates purification (saṁskāramarhati) through prescribed rituals afterwards. This highlights that dharma is not merely about following rules blindly, but about making conscious choices based on circumstances while remaining accountable.

The next verse, addressed to Kunti's son, Arjuna (kaunteya), summarizes the discussion on what is permissible to eat and what is not (abhakṣyabhakṣaṇam). It assures us that through appropriate atonement and expiation (prāyaścittavidhānena), one can purify oneself from any unintentional transgressions. This emphasizes the importance of acknowledging mistakes and actively seeking reconciliation with dharma. It provides solace, suggesting that errors don't define us; instead, our willingness to learn and rectify them does.

The final verse presents a challenging concept regarding the guru-shishya relationship. It states that engaging with the Guru's wife (gurutalpaṁ) does not necessarily defile (na dūṣayati) a man if it is done for the sake of the Guru (gurvarthaṁ). The example of Uddalaka begetting Svetaketu through his disciple is cited. This is not an endorsement of adultery, but a complex illustration of dharma operating at a higher level, where the lineage and continuation of knowledge are paramount. It challenges your conventional understanding of morality, urging you to consider the potential for actions to be driven by a deeper sense of duty.

In modern life, these verses prompt us to navigate ethical dilemmas with discernment. Sometimes, strict adherence to rules may be less dharmic than acting with compassion and wisdom, particularly in crisis situations. When you inevitably stumble, remember the power of atonement and self-reflection. The story of Uddalaka encourages you to question assumptions and consider the motivations behind actions, recognizing that dharma is not always black and white. It requires constant contemplation and a willingness to engage with the complexities of life.

## REFLECTION FOR TODAY

*How can you apply the principle of "dharma in dire circumstances" to a moral dilemma you are currently facing, ensuring your actions are guided by compassion and wisdom?*